

1. In Victor Hernández Cruz’s poem “Two Guitars,” published in 2001, the speaker imagines that two guitars are alive and engaging in conversation about their musical experiences. Read the poem carefully. Then, in a well-written essay, analyze how Hernández Cruz uses literary elements and techniques to convey a complex portrayal of the guitars’ musical world.

In your response you should do the following:

- Respond to the prompt with a thesis that presents a defensible interpretation.
- Select and use evidence to support your line of reasoning.
- Explain how the evidence supports your line of reasoning.
- Use appropriate grammar and punctuation in communicating your argument.

### Two Guitars

Two guitars were left in a room all alone  
They sat on different corners of the parlor  
In this solitude they started talking to each other  
My strings are tight and full of tears  
*Line 5* The man who plays me has no heart  
I have seen it leave out of his mouth  
I have seen it melt out of his eyes  
It dives into the pores of the earth  
When they squeeze me tight I bring  
*10* Down the angels who live off the chorus  
The trios singing loosen organs  
With melodious screwdrivers  
Sentiment comes off the hinges  
Because a song is a mountain put into  
*15* Words and landscape is the feeling that  
Enters something so big in the harmony  
We are always in danger of blowing up  
With passion

The other guitar:

- 20 In 1944 New York  
 When the Trio Los Panchos<sup>1</sup> started  
 With Mexican & Puerto Rican birds<sup>2</sup>  
 I am the one that one of them held  
 Tight like a woman
- 25 Their throats gardenia<sup>3</sup> gardens  
 An airport for dreams  
 I've been in theaters and cabarets  
 I played in an apartment on 102nd street  
 After a baptism pregnant with women
- 30 The men flirted and were offered  
 Chicken soup  
 Echoes came out of hallways as if from caves  
*Someone is opening the door now*  
 The two guitars hushed and there was a
- 35 Resonance in the air like what is left by  
 The last chord of a bolero.<sup>4</sup>

Victor Hernández Cruz, "Two Guitars" from *Maraca: New and Selected Poems, 1965-2000*. Copyright © 2001 by Victor Hernández Cruz. Reprinted with the permission of Coffee House Press. [www.coffeehousepress.org](http://www.coffeehousepress.org).

**1:** a musical group that specializes in boleros and other romantic ballads

**2:** guitars

**3:** a type of plant known for its striking flowers

**4:** a genre of romantic music that originated in Cuba and has been popular throughout the Americas; common themes include unrequited love, betrayal, and abandonment